Chiang Kai-shek's KMT forces. But fighting between the Communists and the Nationalists broke out again after the Japanese defeat in 1945, and the revolutionaries now came to be known as the PLA. By the time World War II was over and the civil war began, the Communist forces had over 900,000 regular troops and 2 million in militia units.[12]

The KMT was defeated and Chiang Kai-shek escaped to the island of Taiwan, where his Republic of China lived on along with the futile hope of reclaiming the mainland someday. That was not to be, and, on 1 October 1949 before hundreds of thousands of cheering people, the Communist leader Mao Zedong proclaimed the People's Republic of China, saying, 'Never again will the people of China be an enslaved people!'[13]

Mao has been hailed in official Chinese history as a military genius, but that is a myth which became part of the bizarre personality cult that was developed around him in the 1960s. Mao was a political rather than a military leader. The actual commander and founder of the Red Army and the PLA was Zhu De, a warlord in the southern provinces of Yunnan and Sichuan who had joined the Communists during the Nanchang uprising. Zhu had begun his revolutionary career as a Great Elder of a lodge of Gelaohui, one of China's most powerful secret societies. He was also an opium addict until he received treatment in Shanghai in the early 1920s. It was not Mao but Zhu who, despite his dubious personality, formulated the operational principles of mobile warfare summed up in the famous maxim:

> When the enemy advances, we retreat.
> When the enemy halts and encamps, we harass them.
> When the enemy seeks to avoid battle, we attack.
> When the enemy retreats, we pursue.[14]

Zhu remained the PLA commander-in-chief through 1954 and held several political positions until he was purged during the Cultural Revolution in the late 1960s. Mao may not have been a military commander, but his contribution to the Communist military doctrine was his famous slogan 'political power grows out of the barrel of a gun', which comes from a speech he gave at a meeting with the CCP's Central Committee in November 1938.[15] That phrase has since become the guiding principle for revolutionary movements all over the world. (And to support revolution even in other countries has been a Marxist dogma since Karl Marx himself coined the phrase, 'Workers of all countries, unite!')